

Tringa nebularia

Common greenshank

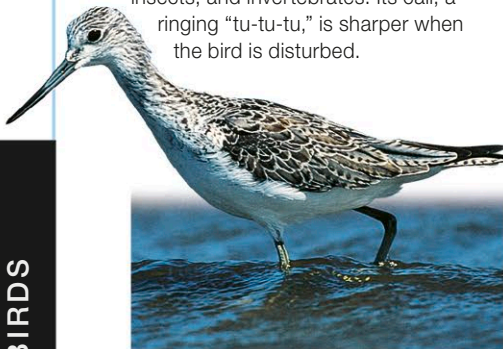


Length 12–14 in (30–35 cm)
Weight 4–11 oz (125–300 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Migrant
Status Least concern

Location Europe, Asia, Africa (mainly south of Sahara)



Like its 13 other relatives in the genus *Tringa*, this long-billed wader is rarely found far from damp ground. It has dark plumage, which is paler below, and long, gray-green legs. When feeding, the greenshank uses the “walk-and-peck” technique used by other members of its genus. It often runs at its prey or scythes through the water with its bill until it finds food, which includes fish, crustaceans, insects, and invertebrates. Its call, a ringing “tu-tu-tu,” is sharper when the bird is disturbed.



Actitis macularius

Spotted sandpiper



Length 7–8 in (18–20 cm)
Weight 1¼–2½ oz (35–70 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Migrant
Status Least concern

Location North, Central, and South America



This small sandpiper has a horizontal posture, short legs, and a stout, 2-toned bill. Greenish brown above, it has pale underparts that are boldly spotted with brown in summer; the female has larger, blacker spots. On the ground, it bobs or teeters in its search for food. As in the red phalarope (see right), the female courts the male, with fanned tail and quivering wings. Some mate with up to 4 males in a season, and show little maternal care.

Phalaropus fulicarius

Red phalarope



Length 7¾–8½ in (20–22 cm)
Weight 1½–2½ oz (40–80 g)
Plumage Sexes differ
Migration Migrant
Status Least concern

Location Circumpolar around Arctic, W. South America, W. Africa



Unlike most waders, which live at or near the water's edge, the red phalarope is an excellent swimmer and spends much of its time either at sea or on muddy pools. It feeds on small animals at the surface and frequently spins around in tight circles to stir up its prey. The red phalarope breeds in marshy ground in the high Arctic tundra, and is remarkable for its breeding behavior. The female takes the lead in courtship, while the male incubates the eggs and rears the young.



ROLE REVERSAL



The red phalarope's breeding system shows an almost complete reversal of the male and female's normal roles. The female—shown above right—is more assertive than the more drably colored male. She establishes a territory and displays to attract a mate, and he takes care of the young.

STOUT WADER

The red phalarope is a small, rather pot-bellied wader with very short legs and a fairly stout bill. The fleshy lobes between the toes help the bird swim.

Gallinago media

Great snipe



Length 10½–11½ in (27–29 cm)
Weight 5–8 oz (150–225 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Migrant
Status Near threatened

Location N. Europe, N.W. Asia, Africa



The 18 species of snipes are long-billed and beautifully camouflaged waders that feed mostly under cover of darkness. Like most snipes, the great snipe has a



pointed, 2-toned bill. There is extensive dark barring on the underparts, and the tail corners have more white than most other snipes. In the breeding season, male birds gather at a display ground (lek) and compete with each other, using a variety of sounds. After mating, the female nests alone.

Calidris canutus

Red knot



Length 9–10 in (23–25 cm)
Weight 3½–8 oz (100–225 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Migrant
Status Near threatened

Location Worldwide, except Antarctica



One of the largest of all sandpipers of the genus *Calidris*, the red knot has gray plumage in winter, but during the breeding season, its face and underparts

turn brick-red, while the upperparts are dark and spotted with pale chestnut. Red knots travel up to 7,500 miles (12,000 km) to breed, and form large flocks when feeding and roosting.



Chionis albus

Snowy sheathbill



Length 13½–16 in (34–41 cm)
Weight 16–28 oz (450–775 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Partial migrant
Status Least concern

Location S.E. South America, Falkland Islands, Antarctic Peninsula



The 2 species of sheathbills constitute the only bird family whose breeding range is entirely confined to the Antarctic and sub-Antarctic region. This species scavenges for food at penguin and seal colonies, feeding on eggs, chicks, and seals' afterbirth, and harassing penguins into regurgitating the food they bring for their young. It makes a cup-shaped nest from grass, bones, pebbles, shells, and feathers.

Stercorarius antarcticus

Brown skua



Length 20½–25 in (52–64 cm)
Weight 2¼–4½ lb (1–2 kg)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Partial migrant
Status Least concern

Location Circumpolar around Antarctica



Skuas breed in high latitudes, at times close to polar ice. The brown skua is one of 4–6 species in its genus and the most widespread species in the far south. This gull-like scavenger preys on penguins, shearwaters, and other seabirds of the southern oceans, particularly on their eggs and young, and scavenges around fishing boats and ships.

